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Toshiko Akiyoshi

Pianist, composer and band leader Toshiko Akiyoshi was born in Dairen, China on December 12, 1929. Her family resettled in Japan in 1947 where she absorbed the sounds of jazz that was popular with American servicemen. Toshiko found steady work in clubs and theaters and later pursued a career in jazz in the U.S. After studies at Berklee, she performed and recorded with Charlie Mariano and Charles Mingus, and established herself as a highly regarded bop pianist. She founded a L.A. rehearsal band with her husband Lew Tabackin in 1973 which eventually established itself as one of the most innovative large jazz ensembles in modern jazz. Her unique composing voice often combines elements of Japanese culture, and in 1984 she was the subject of a documentary, "Jazz is my Native Language." Toshiko now directs her orchestra in New York while performing and recording with small ensembles.

Toshiko was interviewed in New York City on January 17, 1999, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today in Manhattan for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. It's my pleasure to be speaking with Toshiko Akiyoshi, who is a renown band leader.

TA: I wouldn't say that.

MR: I think so.

TA: Thank you.

MR: Pianist and composer. And I'll make a quote from the *All Music Guide to Jazz* that called you "one of the top arrangers of the last 25 years." And I suspect that you might have preferred that they call you a composer?

TA: I think probably because in my case both is the same. I don't really — as a rule — I don't arrange somebody else's music. I have done a few numbers of Lew's. I've done two to the exception, one Dizzy Gillespie one, and another one, Frank Wess was with the band for ten years. It was my gift to him along with his tune. Other than that I don't do that stuff.

MR: That's an interesting scenario to write an arrangement for someone who's a great arranger themselves.

TA: Yes. I think sometimes, to me an arranger is something, you look at a piece and you look at a different aspect of that particular tune. Perhaps the writer itself didn't think about that when he or she had written that particular piece of music. I think that makes an arranger interesting, I think looking at it a different way. Like in the old days, the famous story about the four blind persons and they're describing an elephant. And the four of them

touched a different part of the elephant and then they say well the elephant is like a pole or the elephant is like a long hose, or whatever. I think that's probably it.

MR: That's an interesting way, a good analogy. I understand you were born in China and you moved to Japan — you were about 17 is that right?

TA: I was 15 going on 16.

MR: Can I ask why your family moved, and that particular—

TA: The war was ended.

MR: Yeah, that was a very important time for both of those countries.

TA: Yes. I think I was lucky, the fact that I was very little. I think my parents, it was such a terrible blow, especially for my father because, almost he built his business in China, that's why he wanted to remain, that's where he wanted to finish his life. Then the war was ended and he lost everything and it was something that he totally didn't expect. I think it was very difficult for him.

MR: Yeah. What was his business?

TA: Export/import. He was sent to China, in those days called Manchuria, by a big company, a textile company, a Japanese textile company, and they made a big plant in a place called Yoyo [sic]. So that's why my parents left. And after that he left and started his own business. But one thing about when you're very young you can endure a lot I think.

MR: It must have been quite a culture shock.

TA: What was that?

MR: Well China and Japan — my history is not great — but they've had a checkered history over the years. Was it difficult to go from one to the other?

TA: No. Because we all did it — what they call they have a Japanese school. The Japanese community is quite different from the Chinese community. We were in a Japanese community. You know a funny thing about it — 30 years ago I was back in China, now they call it the Yunnan Province old Manchuria, and I visited my own, where I was born, where I went to school, and I didn't realize until then this was down by Inische [sic], and we had a separate community. You know I was too little to realize that. My father's right arm man was a Chinese, and we visited their home and he used to visit our home frequently. And I never realized that we were indeed a separate community I think. So the school we went to, and I never thought about it but there wasn't any Chinese, maybe one or two pupils, but all were Japanese. So all the Japanese education and everything, the old teacher came from the mainland Japan. So there was nothing about that. But we had a Chinese language mandatory class started third year I think it was, the third year. That was mandatory. So we had to learn Chinese, a very difficult language.

MR: I've been told that. It's one of the hardest. What was your exposure to music before you moved to Japan?

TA: Japanese. I don't mean Japanese, I think it was from a major restoration time, which was about 120 or so years ago, when Japan adapted Western culture. The school system came from England. And parts of both came from France. And so everything in education was in Western style. So we — for music we never learned the Japanese music but it was an old western music.

MR: That's really interesting.

TA: So I wish — they had others too. For example my second sister studied Japanese traditional performing art and dancing. But that was after school.

MR: When you moved to Japan, had you started on an instrument before then?

TA: I started to play the piano in third grade when I was seven years old. And the reason was when I was seven, that a nine year old girl played Mozart's [inaudible] you know the Sonata, the third movement, and I really felt I'd like to play just like that. So I asked my parents if I could take lessons for the piano, and that started. And I really loved the instrument. I think that's really my instrument so to speak, when I play I feel very happy.

MR: Was there a pretty strong United States presence in Japan—

TA: After the war?

MR: After the war.

TA: Yes.

MR: Is that how you heard jazz?

TA: Yes. Actually after the war ended, during the war Japan was strictly prohibited from dance halls. Before the war there was a dance hall I understand. I was too little to know about that. But during the war there wasn't anything like that. It was a no-no for the country. So after World War II all of a sudden there's a dance hall. And Americans, you know they are sort of like classified Officers Club or NCO clubs, what have you, and those are even, I think it was an unwritten law I'm not quite sure I don't think official but the black people, they'd have a black soldier's dance hall. And of course the Japanese wanted to dance too. So there was so many dance halls, and there wasn't that many musicians in Japan. So anybody who can play a little bit, they were immediately hired.

MR: Lots of gigs. Wow.

TA: So I really wanted to touch piano, and you can imagine my parents all of a sudden they couldn't buy a piano for me. So I took a job in a dance hall. And I think it was lucky for me, and for the Japanese people. And one of the Japanese young men, he's not young anymore now, every once in a while, his name is Mr. Figree, and he was a jazz record

collector. And somehow he thought I had potentiality. So he invited me over to his home and played a traditional record. It's a kind of famous story. And he played the Teddy Wilson, "Sweet Lorraine." And I thought I wanted to play just like that. That's my first introduction. It was in 1947 I believe.

MR: So you went from wanting to play just like Mozart, to just like Teddy Wilson. That's good company. You could do a lot worse.

TA: Yeah.

MR: When was the first time that you might have had to deal with chord symbols, or just a lead sheet as opposed to a written score?

TA: When I got the job. As I said the manager asked me, I saw this "pianist wanted." So I go inside and the manager came out and he said, "Can you play piano?" I said, "Yes." He said, "Well come in at 7:00 tonight" — it could be 6:00, it was early. And so I go there and I see five people. The band leader was an ex-Navy officer who played the violin. And there was a great — violin and accordion and drums and a piano, and alto saxophone. No bass. And that's the first time I saw a chord symbol. And I'd never seen them before. So I said, "What is this?" She said, "You don't know this?" I said, "No I don't." So she said, "Let me hear you play the piano." So I said well — I played a Sonata, Beethoven's number three [scats]. And she said, "Oh she can play piano." So she said, "Well just do what you think you can do and if you are here I'll teach you how to read a chord symbol the next day." That's what it was. And I really thought that that was jazz and that what it was, nothing but noisy, and I really didn't like it. But I had access to the piano in the afternoon, so that was wonderful. In the daytime I can just play piano, because the dance hall was only open in the evening. So from the first day, yeah.

MR: So then this person would show you what major seven meant and all those kinds of things.

TA: Yes. But I think probably he wasn't very informed either, when you look back. But those days, I thought everybody sounded better than myself so everybody, when they suggested to me to do something I did it.

MR: Sort it out later.

TA: Yes. Exactly.

MR: So Teddy Wilson — now I think I had read that you had a chance encounter with Oscar Peterson?

TA: Yes. The first great pianist I had met actually in person was Oscar Peterson. That was in 1953 I believe. That was the first time the American jazz group came to Japan for the Japanese audience. Before that a few groups came to Japan but they were for the USO

tour for the American troops. For example, Louis Armstrong was there one time, and the Gene Krupa Trio was there one time, and way before that, in 1950 I believe there was a dance band, Les Brown's band with Bob Hope. But more than anything, I think '51, I'm not quite sure, there is Oscar Pettiford the leader, and J.J. Johnson and Howard McGhee, they were also on the USO tour. And Charlie Rice, the drummer, I forgot the name of the guitar player, they didn't have a pianist for the USO tour, because the piano you know is not always there, so they didn't usually have a pianist. They'd have a guitar, and Rudy Willliams, who used to be with Lionel Hampton, a tenor player, he'd play and dance and lie down on the floor.

MR: Oh yeah, the whole show.

TA: That was very exciting to me actually. They played in the Ernie Pyle camp. You know after the war was occupation time. Many American organizations they'd say a headquarter for this, and da-da-da-da-dah. They took over a Japanese public building. So this theater belonged to the Japanese, a performing group, a very famous group called Calazipie [sic] — all girls. And they took that theater and made it Ernie Pyle's Theater. And that's where they came. And the Japanese are not supposed to be there. It's off limits to Japanese. It's for Americans, although it's a Japanese club. So I already had a big — what I call — it's like groupies. I had American groupies. So one person was in the Air Force, we used to call him Mac, his real name is Harry McCutcheon I think. But Mac we used to call him. He actually invited me to listen to the group. And I knew if I went there I was going to be late for my work. But I just couldn't help it so I was late for work. And my band leader in the group, it was a sextet, the tenor player was the leader, and he was steaming mad. But they came with me to clubs so that kind of made it a little bit cool. It was very exciting. And that's the first time I heard someone actually warm up. J.J. would say, Mac would introduce me to J.J. and he came up and said, "Excuse me, I have to warm up" and he played a long tone. I never heard that before, not before that. I was with a big band prior to that maybe two or three different big bands. But I never heard a Japanese player doing that. So that was very impressive to me.

MR: Yeah. Something as simple as that, that concept of preparing for your performance.

TA: Right.

MR: How did your father feel about your continued involvement in music?

TA: Well firstly he was very, very upset because in the Japanese, traditionally middle class family on, daughters are not supposed to work. They marry someone. And on top of that playing in dance halls, my God, that's an evil place. But I was paid tremendous money in those days. And it was very helpful for the family. And coupled with that my mother sort

of talked him into it. Actually this was in the fall of ’46, and I was supposed to go to medical school. And the school in Japan starts in the springtime, so it’s not like September. So my mother said well until she starts school, so that cooled my father. Then by the time that came they thought well she didn’t become a juvenile delinquent or anything, so that was that.

MR: Interesting. When did it first come up that you might actually come to the States to study?

TA: Well in those days there were a couple of ways to learn new music, and also the language, as I said, of records. I used to copy records one at a time and then fortunately later on I was hired in a band to play in an officer’s club and then they taught me, and they had one of those record players, and they had in those days called V-discs, like twelve inches I think. And I could play and I could listen and then I could copy that. It didn’t matter if it was a saxophone player, I just copied everything. And that’s the way you learn the idiosyncrasies of improvisation. Then later when I went to Tokyo, this was [inaudible] and then it started getting jazz coffee shops, where you can have a cup of coffee and myself for example, stay for about two or three hours and try to learn some tunes. Because that was only where — there was a thousand Tin Pan Alley music or something. There was nothing about the books.

MR: Oh, no fake books.

TA: No, nothing. So you learn that way. And there’s another very precious lesson in those days, were drafted musicians from here, professional ones, some of them noteworthy like Hampton Hawes for example that’s a noted player. Even those not that noted, Eddie Costa. There was a drum player, later he was playing with Eddie’s group or somebody like that. But anyway, there were quite many good players in Japan in the Army and, not Navy, but Air Force band. And they would come and sit in where I had my own group. And I learned some tunes that way. And there was a Barney Benton. Later he was, in a short time he was with Max Roach’s group. But he didn’t like New York so he quit anymore. That was quite some time ago. But at that time, this was somewhere like in 1954, so after I had this chance making records for Norman Granz which was in ’53, Oscar Peterson would come also. But this is maybe after. But still all the tunes you have to learn from that way, a soldier or a record.

MR: Did you start writing them down, or did they just become memorized immediately yourself?

TA: At one time I used to write out everything. I remember I had quite a lot of standards a long time ago, like 78 records. But most of the time, much later I just played a number of them. This is when I got very much into Bud Powell. And after that I think I would just

play his record and I just learned how to play like that. And by that time I had my little piano so mostly, most of the memorization was later on. First, early days, I used to copy it and put it on a tape.

MR: You came to Berklee in ’56 was it?

TA: Yes.

MR: This concept of going to school to learn jazz, was that a revelation?

TA: Not really. Actually what brought me here to the States is that I became more and more a big frog in a little pond. I mentioned earlier that if you can play you have a job. And it’s still to the point where even though ’54, ’55, still there were enough jobs and I could almost say if I started to play saxophone then, if I could just play a little bit I’d probably get a job as a saxophone player. So there was no reason for a musician to become better at it.

MR: Yeah. You weren’t challenged at all.

TA: Yeah. And the only things you become better at it because you want to become better at it. You want to become a little more better than what you were doing before. So there were a few self motivated musicians. I’m not going to name them, but very few. So I was a very big, as I said, frog in a little pond, but I knew there were so many things that I can improve on. But I could not do it in Japan because everybody came to the point where they weren’t better than I. For example like everybody asked about Sadao Watanabe, who was a big name, and then when he came to my group he was only 17, turned 18, and I had to show him a lot of things. So if you come to that position, I don’t really think it’s a good position to be in if you are not quite that great yet. In my case I certainly wasn’t great yet. I had so many things that I had to improve upon. But jazz, as you know, is a very unique art, that you can’t learn in a studio, you have to play with others surrounding who are better than you, then you get better at it. So that wasn’t happening in Japan. So I really wanted to come to the United States and in those days it was very difficult. You can only come as a student with what they call an F Visa.

MR: What was that?

TA: F. Form F, that school has to approve, and the school would have to have that qualification. Not every little private school could do it. So things like that. And there was a guitar player from Boston that was drafted, and he told me about this school. In those days it was called Berklee School for Music and before that it used to be called Schillinger House. And I knew about the book, a lot of so noted, like Gershwin for example, they studied with Joseph Schillinger. So that’s what they were teaching. So I thought well, he suggested that I should write a letter. Meanwhile I had a record out from

Norman Granz. And when I wrote the letter to the school that I wished to be accepted in the school, and that Norman Granz had written a big article about me simultaneously while he was releasing my record, it was a ten inch in those days, and the school noticed that, so they decided — it was a very small school at that time. So I think it works better for both of us that they gave me a full scholarship, the school got a lot of publicity because of that too. So that's how I came to school in Boston. And then I started playing from the third month. In January '56 I started playing Storyville in March. But I think one thing the school did for me was impart a filing cabinet. That's a fun way of saying it. I knew about all those things that they was teaching as far as arranging and [inaudible]. The Schillinger system, this is something else. I think I got quite a lot out of it, even though it's not appliable directly, but still it broadens your scope so to speak. But I was doing everything before that, I was arranging and I had nonet, a regular radio broadcast in Japan, so I had to write for nonet. So I was doing all this, but I was doing all this by my experience as going through sort of like a trial and error so to speak. So school had, let's say I could analyze what I did. It was like my brain and the inside of my brain, maybe like a file, kind of put it into perspective so to speak. I think school did that for me.

MR: I like that. Was that the first, at Berklee — let me rephrase — when was the first chance you had to write for a whole big band?

TA: Probably about second year. They had a concert and the school asked me to write a chart for a concert. I had written a three movement piece. The second movement was with strings, the first movement was straight, the third movement had tympani and all of that whole thing. I'm not quite sure if it was good or not. Perhaps it wasn't.

MR: Was it your own composition too?

TA: Yes.

MR: Well you jumped right into it, didn't you?

TA: I don't know.

MR: Instead of just writing maybe a fairly straight ahead blues chart, you did your own thing.

TA: Yeah, I think at that point I had ten years before that before I came to this country, I had ten years of my career in Japan. And I was doing pretty okay, I got to the point where I was playing probably faster than anybody and longer than anybody. That's the whole thing. But a big band was something that I wasn't quite interested in. I was interested in the individual players. I was mainly, and more than anything I was interested in my piano playing to be improved a little more. I sort of thought I could, and I always thought I could a little more improve, I could a little bit more improve. So that was because the school requested, that's why I wrote that. That never was my ambition, it wasn't at all. I

became interested in writing much, much later, perhaps ’67, around there. Actually in ’67 I had my own concert, my own produced, to try and get money for work and so on, at the Town Hall and at that time I thought, I was hoping that if some people noticed me, and I had a solo and trio, and about four big band charts. And when I was rehearsing that I felt that’s what I wanted to do. I felt like that’s what I wanted to do. Because up to that point I was getting a little bit of anxiety about the fact that, as you know I had a quartet at one time with Mariano and so on, but it wasn’t enough color for me. I said I needed more color. So I had this anxiety, I couldn’t fully express my thoughts so to speak. So when I did that I felt like oh that’s what I’d like to do. I think that’s what I feel very comfortable wanting about — I always played and I always said afterward, why did I do that? I shouldn’t have done that. And while I’m playing I said oh I did it again. I didn’t think I ever would have said oh my God I did it again. So writing is something you can take your time, if you don’t like it you can change, so on, so on. So I think that’s maybe one part of it and if I were painting I’d probably need a lot of color. I think that’s probably it. But I couldn’t really do it. I didn’t have the money, so it was a rehearsal band so to speak, until 1972, we moved to, because of Lew’s job with the Tonight Show, he went to Los Angeles and out from boredom he remembered that I had four charts, so he suggested he would get the musicians together and we rehearsed every Wednesday morning from 10:15. Fifty cents for two hours. The union had a rehearsal and still do, I think it’s $5 now, but in those days it was fifty cents for two and half hours or something like that. So that’s how it started. And people wanted to hear and so on and so on. But I never wanted, I still don’t, as a rule I’m not interested in big bands.

MR: That’s an interesting statement. I mean you certainly made an impact and kept that tradition alive. You know when you read about your music, most people mention that it brings in a whole other area of influence from your native culture. And when you write do you consciously try to think of things from your youth that are now combined with American jazz, or is it just kind of part of you?

TA: No. Actually I never thought about it until Duke Ellington died. Before that, you know it was just a Japanese traditional concept, or being Japanese playing jazz was some sort of a handicap. When I was growing up in Japan as a player, they always said that Filipino people have better feeling than Japanese, and indeed the Filipino players played better than us, and it’s simply because they have a longer history. They weren’t under — they were colonized by America so they are more exposed for jazz, much longer than we were. I think that would have to be. Today no one say that anymore. So when I was in Japan a critical compliment to me, and the phrases they used was, “Her playing smells of

butter." The smell of butter means very American. Because butter is western. Japanese traditionally, we have no butter. So they used to say her playing smells of butter. That's what they used to say. So that has been going on for a long time. When Duke Ellington died, it was '73, or '74 I think, and there was a *Village Voice*, Nat Hentoff had a memoir. And he was talking about that fact that Duke was, how proud he was about his race. And he was pointing out so many music was based on his race, which I knew some but I never thought of it that way until someone pointed — "Black Butterfly" "Black and Tan Fantasy," what have you. So that's what actually triggered me. I think everything you do is sort of inviting. The dark time comes because everything else is something developing underneath. And it's almost like a volcano and if something triggers it that becomes. I think in my case it was Duke Ellington, that memoir, written by Nat Hentoff. And I thought that's what I should — I should look into my heritage before, because one I have a long career as a jazz player and I came a very good time in this country where no one cares and no club owner would cares if you pack them in or not. You will do the routine, the circuit, the jazz club circuit. Even for example the greatest classic Miles Davis Quintet, like Red Garland, Philly Jo, Coltrane, Paul Chambers. The people did not come. I mean at Storyville they'd come only, the weekend was the only time. On the weeknights, not that many people were there. Those are the times. But the clubs wasn't so uptight about that. So I caught the tail end of that I went through. Also the great players like Oscar Pettiford was living and he used to come to the Hickory House when I was playing in the summertime, almost every night, sitting in, meaning he didn't have a job. You know in those days, I feel very bad for him but at the same time those were the days that if people didn't have a job, and they were great players, and the jazz music business wasn't quite so organized or productionized as of today. They were very open, so I could sit in with Monk's group if I know the tune, which I did, and things like that. That was my very valuable asset. And all that I think was the basic foundation of my writing. So my long years of playing and the timing was right for me to come to this country, to be able to play with these players was the most valuable lesson you could possibly get. I think that is my asset, not everybody can have. So I sort of wait, where I've had a long career as a jazz player, but I have a different heritage, and always I never even thought about looking into my heritage. But because of the article I said I would look into it. Probably I have a different heritage than American players, and I should try to draw from that, perhaps I can make it a little bit different. As you know jazz history and music history did not include the oriental influence. So at least I can infuse something to make it a little bit different and perhaps I can return something to the jazz

community or history that has been pretty good to me. However people always say that, you know I barely played for about thirteen years, and the people always say well you had a terrible time, a difficult time. And I never thought I am having a difficult time. Because everybody else did I thought. When I look back I think those times were very important times. If I didn't have that I probably didn't come to that conclusion. I think it's having sort of like, not a battle, but to become more warm. It's very difficult. It's literally— you know I say there is a certain animal they go sleep in the wintertime.

MR: Hibernation?

TA: They go hibernate. But it's not really a hibernation but there's a time when you are, and then you accumulate a lot of thought, all the things you accumulate. And that was my thirteen years I think. And that I think was a very important time for me. So I think everything worked the way it should be.

MR: That's fascinating, really. Was it a challenge then to, you started delving into oriental music and themes and so forth, to transfer that to this big band format?

TA: Yes. I think that first of all — excuse me — I would like to think my big band is a real — it's an extension of a small group, that's the way I like to think. But there are many things that happen because of the first band, what they could do and so on and so on, I utilize them, blah blah blah blah. But when — as I say before — I decided at least I should try that. I was very fascinated by a Japanese drum called kotsuzumi, because my late father was a student of Noh, N-O-H, a man's performing art, he was a student of Noh and it was very familiar to me, and this is primitive works but they have such a beautiful sound and two headed drums and a tight string and played like this, and another one played like that. This one is bigger, it makes a higher pitch. The one that's smaller, this makes a lower sound pitch, a little more resonant, and you change with a squeezed string. Also you change the pitch with, there's a certain Japanese paper. You keep putting in to the change pitch, you know the way you like. That's what they do. But I was very fascinated with that, I always wanted to utilize that. So that was around "Kogun" was the first one, that was 1974. But I always think that it's just enough to make it effective, but it's not going to be a major takeover, something like Brazilian music that became sort of a major change in the jazz scene, like the things called samba jazz or what have you. And it would never become that way but it's a little different. And also there are a few things when I was with Mingus, he used to bend the note, which is very much oriental. And I don't think he did it purposely but when I was with his group we rehearsed without anything. He would sing and you would have to kind of imitate it. So he sang and then the saxophone player and trumpet player would have to imitate what he sings. I think

that's the best way to learn music I think. So some of the music was like a little bended a certain way, and I think that's also very common in Japanese music, many notes are bended. The artistry of the Japanese instrumental music, it's another skill but to change the shape of one note. That's the artistry, and that includes bending a note also, so on and so on. So I think it becomes more like a color, a little bit different I think.

MR: Did you have to use some different kinds of notation to get those kinds of effects out of the saxophones and the trumpets?

TA: No. You know what I do? I just write a slide, I say "play sticky."

MR: Play sticky.

TA: People say what does that mean? Sticky? What does that mean? It's funny though. But when grew up in Japan in a big band, in the old days, everything would go like this. You don't go WOP but you have a pause in a note, open and close. And I'm very sensitive about the long and the short. A drum for example. A drum plays, and then also, that one is just a staccato, that's different to me. This must have bottom. Staccato doesn't have to have bottom to me. But jazz, the main thing, I think the big band, the most important thing to me is that it must have a bottom a lot of times. I think it also depends on — so you very rely on the rhythm section. If the rhythm section doesn't have a bottom it's kind of hard to do. But the old musicians used to say heavy bottom. That's it. Excuse me one moment.

[pause]

MR: I want to make sure — how much parking do you have in your —

MR: I wanted to play just, oh I don't know, about twelve measures of something here.

[audio interlude]

MR: First of all I have to say it's pretty challenging music.

TA: You know I never have written to make it difficult. But because my music, the foundation is bebop music, because that's how I grew up. So bebop music, as you know, it's a virtuoso music, it became virtuoso music after bebop. So consequently there are a lot of notes. And consequently it's difficult. But I think a long time ago some classical musician said "the music has no difficulty but good and bad." So sometimes music comes out difficult. Sometimes easy. But it doesn't matter. Because most of the time I think in the classical field, they don't really say that. And sometimes I think consider the challenge — if the pianist can play let's say Rachmaninoff Concerto 3 or something like that and they consider it's like a real technician, something like that, but they consider that challenging, they will not ever, ever — at least in my experience — say how come that was so hard. They don't say that. But as for jazz somehow people say that. I heard a

long time ago somebody criticized my music, this was like over 15 years ago, said, "How come her music sounds so hard?" So Lew said, "Well hard yesterday, okay today, easy tomorrow." So I think that's why it tends to be difficult. But it's two to tango you know. The musician, a good musician, I like to think they like challenging music. They will not — you know men, I shouldn't say men — but a few of the artists, men and women both of them, live on bread alone. So I think challenging music is something that they would like — a challenge.

MR: Well most of them, in L.A. a lot of the fellows and the women were working studio jobs and so forth, so they must have really relished this opportunity.

TA: I think the Los Angeles band were creatures of the first band. It was very important in many different ways but one thing was that because of the saxophone player, all of them doubled because most of them were studio players. So because they doubled, I utilized that. And that became a trademark of my writing. So everything is sort of like it goes both ways. If they didn't double I wouldn't have it written. And a long time ago when I was in Japan I heard somebody's music, a woodwind, maybe third stream or something, it was sort of fast, and I heard — but to me that wasn't jazz, and if I were writing for woodwinds I would not write like that. So that was the opportunity for me to write. So it was the first band that was a very important band. Also the first band was very important for me because I never touted so many musicians in my life. It was after I came to this country, a trio or quartet, and no more than that. So it was a totally different story with so many musicians you have to deal with it. And pianists tend to be — at least I am — tend to be paranoia. And it took me a long time to get over taking everything personally. And so I grew up as a human being with the first band I think. So that was a very important band.

MR: Not only musically then but in a lot of ways.

TA: Yes.

MR: It must have been a struggle just economically and logistically for that many people — to get them to rehearsals.

TA: Well everyone came to rehearsals because they liked it. No one got paid — still don't today. You know we do rehearsals but no one gets paid. In New York you pay your own subway token or what have you. And in Los Angeles it's the same. Everybody came to rehearse. And on Wednesday morning that was something for them to do, and later on when people said I would like to have a band to have a concert here, and I was so inexperienced so I will book a hotel that was more than the payroll. So the musician would lose money, and things like that. It was really a disaster. For a long time, I had to

do everything — airplane arrangements, hotel arrangements, bus arrangements. So it was a learning process for me, and I think with the first band paid a lot of dues.

MR: You know you made a statement — I think it was the liner notes to this particular CD, that you feel very strongly that leaving behind your own compositions is even more important than your own recordings, that this is kind of a legacy for you? Did I interpret that statement okay? It sounded like it was very important for you as a person to be leaving original work.

TA: Yes I think so. I always said first of all, before, earlier I made a statement, the fact that I think I needed more color to express my — playing and writing, to me it was the same. And I used to write for my playing and it wasn't enough to express myself as thoroughly. It wasn't just playing a nice bebop figure. It wasn't that. It was something more towards to attitude if you will, or philosophical view if you will, the certain things you think about. That becomes very important for me. That's why I think I needed more color. When I started doing this people started to pay attention. Before that I would learn that people would offer me jobs, but I really never made any revolution so to speak. Oscar Peterson developed this, called the "Oscar Peterson style," somewhere from Canada. George Shearing came from England and there was a "Shearing style" a long time ago in 1950 everybody played that. So what did I do, the "Toshiko style" piano. I didn't make any revolution. I really felt like sort of insignificant. Since I started writing people seem to pay attention, they seem to hear something new, something that wasn't there before, and so on. And so I have to say my value lies as a writer, as a musician. And because it was so many years, just like any other musician, you know my record became quickly collectors items. I was very used to that, I missed not selling anything. So it was the first one, a big seller, actually I was very surprised. And this was in L. A., the first recording after rehearsing every Wednesday. And I was basically saying — I mean I say the same thing now too — but I've been lucky that I can actually witness — my sort of success, so that I don't have to worry about paying the rent and things like that, I'm very lucky. But I think even now, I think of the two let's say — I don't know how to say it in English — judgment, the final judgment will have to be after my death, that's what I think. So it was very important. Especially in those days, it was more important. It's still equally important now, but at that time it was very important because I never had any success.

MR: Right. You definitely found your niche here I guess.

TA: Yes. But when I'm writing and I'm getting sort of recognition, at the same time there was a writer or reviewer who will put me down for something that I consider it wasn't fair, but it doesn't matter, whatever it was. Or people will say, "Are you sure Lew didn't help

you out?" Or when the first RCA, the first one came out, "Long Yellow Road" the press release went with the recording, I saw it later, Leonard Feather showed it to me, he could not believe it, and it said, "Lew writes all the arrangements."

MR: Oh dear.

TA: So all these things were happening and sometimes some critic will say, "I question her authenticity." So all this, so I think that comes with it. If you're doing something people think is something new, whatever it is, and also my heritage. If I was standing on the street, no one will notice me. And if I say to them, "I am a jazz player" and everybody will say, "Funny, she doesn't look like a jazz player." So there are many things unnatural about what I'm doing. It doesn't fit together. So I think those things come with it. And I will be lying if I say it doesn't bother me. It does bother me to some degree but it really, the bottom line is it doesn't bother me. As I said if the music is good enough it's going to leave behind, at my death.

MR: Right. It's going to override all those people who sometimes it seems like it seems like the critics have to have a certain amount of negative things to say.

TA: Otherwise it's not a review.

MR: Yeah. It's like giving out parking tickets. I haven't given out enough parking tickets today, I'd better find some more. Well you came back to New York from L.A. in what year?

TA: '83. Actually '82 November. We started a New York band, the present band in '83 March I believe.

MR: I see some great players on your records.

TA: Oh yes. Also it's interesting to me the fact that when the first band was — ten years was the first band. And somebody was like, let's say 23 years old, then they were 33 years old. And now the present band, this is its 16th year. And so when they were mid-twenties, they are 40 now. So we all kind of grow together, and then I can have like just a little taste of history, like the Duke had thirty years with his band.

MR: Yeah, that's right.

TA: I taste a little of that.

MR: That's nice and you can personalize the music maybe to some of the players.

TA: Yeah.

MR: Just a couple more things. When you first conceive of a new piece, let's suppose you get a commission you or have a reason to really write something new, where does it start? Do you sit at the piano?

TA: Actually as you know some of what I consider as important pieces is programmatic music — programmatic music, I think that's what it's called. It's like it could be a ballet. So there's a story to tell. And some of the things I'd like to tell the story, for example the existence of a courtesan in Doronin a Japanese courtesan in Doronin. It's very unique. Or a mercury poisoning in Minimata. Certain stories like I like to tell. I go by, see writing, the first thing is the listener. So I as a listener, when I finish listening to this particular piece, I like to feel this way. As writer I want to give the listener to feel that way. It's certain things that it has to convey. It's not intellectual, but certain emotional feeling we must receive from that particular piece. So for that what notes you will choose? So I go from backwards. Then after maybe I think I have this certain structure, a melodic structure or something, I went to the piano I go, then I sit on it the next day and the next day see if that is still good. And a lot of times it's not.

MR: It didn't hold up.

TA: Yes. But sometimes it's easy to come, sometimes it's difficult to come. It's really hard to tell, but sometimes it comes very easy and sometimes it's very difficult. But by my experience, if I just hang in there I know I will come up with something. So I don't give up.

MR: Well this has just been a fascinating conversation. I hope that the band stays together.

TA: I hope so too, yes.

MR: I know it must be, with all those people, a difficult proposition, to keep a corps of—

TA: Yes. A band like mine can't exist without the musicians, every musician wants to belong to the band, that wants to play this music. Other than that it cannot exist. Because it's very little monetary reward. So I think I'm very lucky. Also musicians like to gather with good musicians. That's another thing.

MR: Your husband told me that it's kind of a difficult proposition to take your place in the band.

TA: Oh that's not quite true.

MR: Well he doesn't feel like he's a good leader, plus he said that there's no piano parts.

TA: No piano parts, because I think a big band is somewhat like chamber music. You know it's that much, only about 16, 17 people. Now chamber music you don't really need a piano, unless it's written especially for piano, or to play that part in certain positions. I have a couple of tunes like that. But other than that you don't need a piano. Especially Lew, the supremo player, I think he's one of the truly great players. He's also very dedicated. I always say I can't afford him if I wasn't married to him. I would have to sell the house.

MR: He wouldn't be in the band if I wasn't married to him.

TA: But he only enjoys playing in the band because he is the principal soloist, he gets to play a lot. Most of the big bands, that's not the case. But he doesn't need a piano. He's the last person to need a piano. But some other people might need a piano. But also I have over 80 pieces of music, so he can choose from that, to not be too noticed.

MR: Dependent, yes. You said that he's hard to write for.

TA: He's hard to write for?

MR: Yeah.

TA: Did I say that?

MR: Yes, but I think it was a comment that you made in one of these things that—

TA: I think anybody is hard to write — but I'm not quite sure what I mean by that. But when I write for him I really, for example, for saxophone, I think about where his, like the low notes, he has such beautiful low notes, which not every tenor player has. And I like to utilize that, especially in a ballad or something. So in the flute case, I don't have too much problem with him, on the very first album "Kogun," I had to ask him, "Could you do this?" I write and then, "Could you do that?" Because there was a lot of bending. And because there was holes, it was a French model I think, they were able to do, and he is supremo in that way. The point is, some of the music, like ballads I have written, especially something like [inaudible] "The Four Seasons" I have a feeling this is my romantic idea, he dies sometimes. I mean everybody dies certain times. I don't think anybody would be able to play it. And the tune will die with him. You know it sounds very romantic I know, but that's the way I feel. And that's I think the beauty of jazz.

MR: Well it's a beautiful sentiment.

TA: Thank you.

MR: And I really appreciate your joining me today.

TA: Oh my pleasure. I had a great time talking, yeah.

MR: Good. Well thank you so much, and best of success to you and I hope the charts keep flowing.

TA: Not flowing, but I hope to be able to come up with something.

MR: Thanks so much.